



COVER
STORY

sons from Europe's long history, and the more recent examples of Turkey, Greece and Bulgaria, in order to conclude 'that the transfer of minorities is the only lasting remedy for communal peace'—a reasoning that led Ambedkar to call for the creation of a 'Dalitstan'. And it was Rajaji who was the first Congress leader, as early as 1942, to accept the legitimacy of the Pakistan idea as a way of safeguarding the rights of Indian Muslims. "What is required now is to concede the ultimate right of regional self-determination," he said in 1943 to the fury of Nehru, who declared it a 'totally intolerable' idea.

It's important to remember that, at that time, there was no widely-accepted description of India, a map that was then torn up by a truculent Jinnah, an impetuous Nehru or whoever 'dunnit'. There was instead much debate over what this future India might look like—a confederation, groupings of provinces, an Indian Union, a mix of princely and other states, a dominion or a republic. To accept that India was a united entity under imperial rule is to accept a central myth of British colonialism. In fact, for Indians in the '40s, geography was by no means seen as given, but as something to be shaped by human decision. Parallel efforts to shape the map were underway across the world, as minorities struggled for recognition and protection (think, for instance, of the Jews, Arabs and Palestine). Seen thus, the Indian predicament, far from being unique, was part of a global one.

Context, in this case more local, is vital also to understand individuals such as Jinnah better. The fact is that for all but one year of his life, Jinnah was a major figure in Indian history, an actor on our historical stage. He was not dropped by a parachute to wrench apart the smoothly turning wheel of the Indian progress. Returning him to his proper place in Indian history allows us to see him more clearly—as a leader wrestling, alongside Ambedkar, Gandhi, Nehru, with the question of how to deal with difference.

Jinnah once expressed a wish to be remembered as the 'Muslim Gokhale', and the ideas and anxieties that shaped him were the same ones that shaped not just Gokhale but Sapru, Gandhi, Nehru, Patel, and Ambedkar. Each of these men struggled in their own ways with the problem of how to establish a political order that could find a place for social and individual diversity. This Indian liberal tradition was more sensitive than its Western variants to

Jinnah sought not purity for Pakistan but parity: not identity, but equality. Pakistan was founded on the assumption that statehood would ensure such parity for the subcontinent's Muslims.



community belonging and minority rights. It had also to operate in a political world split between the language of constitutional legalese and a more demotic speech driven by religious symbolism and imagery.

Jinnah, along with men like Madan Mohan Malaviya and Purushottam Das Tandon, and, of course, Gandhi himself, exemplified this split personality and potentiality of Indian liberalism. Their careers expressed the populist directions that Indian liberalism could take, by invoking religious rhetoric to mobilise masses.

To see Jinnah as an interlocutor in liberal and post-liberal Indian arguments is to understand differently what was at stake during the Partition. The two states of India and Pakistan were indeed created out of a clash, not of civilisations, cultures or religions. It was a clash of opposed views on how to represent minorities and protect them in a future democratic order. The incendiary discourse of religious appeal was present—first muttered under the breath, then spoke more freely. But this clash was conducted largely in the cool vocabulary of modern liberal politics.

Jinnah's arguments were perfectly liberal in the following sense: because of the numerical disproportion between Hindus and Muslims and the

PATEL, NEHRU, MOUNTBATTEN AND JINNAH ACCEPTING THE TRANSFER OF POWER



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